

The Browser Wars

Graphics-capable browsers are responsible for the explosive growth of Internet users ever since the Internet became publicly accessible. Netscape Communications, which was the first to enter the arena, captured the lion's share of the browser market, estimated at a high of about 80% of all users in 1996. Microsoft used the code of the Mosaic browser—which had been co-created by the co-founder of Netscape—in its Internet Explorer, but it did not see the potential of the Web initially, and was slow in pushing its browser. Once it got its act together, it used to its advantage the fact that Windows held more than 90% market share in the operating system market. Microsoft offered Internet Explorer as a free download for all Windows users, while Netscape still charged for its browser (version 4 was the first to be given totally free; earlier versions were free for private users only). Before Windows 98, Internet Explorer was available as a distinct package (Windows Plus package) that had to be separately downloaded and installed. But IE became an integral part of Windows 98 making it the “default” browser. This put Netscape at an disadvantage simply since it required downloading and installing. Besides this, Microsoft was also able to extract commitments from AOL and Apple to use IE as the default browser. While the browser war lasted, each company were quick to launch product updates without adequate quality control... IE4 is credited with winning the war for Microsoft, and it is acknowledged to have implemented W3C specifications with more fidelity than did Netscape 4. By the end of 1998, IE had gained the upper hand.

September: Here Comes Google

Larry Page and Sergey Brin founded Google. They met when they were students at Stanford University. The precursor of Google was a program they created, called BackRub, which analysed back-links to a Web page. (A back-link is the link to it from an external page.) Their experiments with BackRub resulted in the algorithm called PageRank, which used back-links to segregate Web pages based on relevance. The present form of the algorithm consists of 500 million variables and 2 billion terms. Initially, though